

FINDING FLOW

The Psychology of Engagement with Everyday Life

By Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi

The Big “So What”



The book answers the questions: “what is a good life”, “how anyone can create an excellent life” and “how to transform every day activities into an opportunity for engagement, enjoyment and **growth**.” It explains why happiness alone isn’t enough, and how “flow” can create true excellence and quality of life.

Introduction



The insights from the book are built on **3 key assumptions or foundations**:

- Important truths about life have already been captured over the years by philosophers, prophets and sacred books. This book seeks to express and re-interpret them in the modern context.
- Current science provides useful information about mankind. However, our knowledge is still far from complete, and many of the “scientific truths” is by no means proven fact.
- To understand life in the present, we must integrate the realities of the past with the possibilities of the future.

The Content of Experience: What Affects Quality of Life?



To improve our quality of life, we need to first understand how we experience life.



Time is the essence

Our quality of life is essentially the accumulation of

KEY QUOTES

“ ‘To live’...must mean to live in fullness, without waste of time and potential, expressing one’s uniqueness, yet participating intimately in the complexity of the cosmos.”

“There is probably as much superstition and misunderstanding embedded in modern science as there was in the old myths, but we are too close in time to tell the difference.”

“One of the most essential decisions any of us can make is about how one’s time is allocated or invested.”

experiences (what we do, feel, think) over time. Since experiences take place at a point in time, time is the scarcest resource that we have. **How we choose to allocate or invest time will determine what we experience, which add up to determine our quality of life.**



What we do

Whenever we think about or do something, it consumes psychic energy. **Most of us spend our time and psychic energy in these proportions:**



24-60% on **productive activities** to generate energy for survival (e.g. working, studying, eating)



20-42% on **maintenance activities** (e.g. commuting, grooming, housework)



20-43% on **leisure activities**

Thought leaders and philosophers have long suggested that people start to develop their true potential during their “leisure time”, when they can devote their time and energy to self-development.



Who we are with

Our experiences (and hence quality of life) are largely affected by the people we are with. Most people spend their time evenly in 3 social contexts:



“Public” space, where we are evaluated by others, compete for resources & may establish collaborative relationships. This is the domain that presents the highest risks and also the highest rewards.



Family, including time with parents, siblings, children and close relatives.



Solitude, i.e. time on our own, which may be enjoyable to some but not to others.



Our intentions and goals

Our intentions focus our psychic energy in the short run, while our goals focus our energy in the long run, and this in turn shapes who we become.

KEY QUOTES

“Without a consistent set of goals, it is difficult to develop a coherent self.”

Immersing/focusing on our goals typically takes a lot of psychic energy:

 **Managing our goals** can take up a lot of energy, especially those that go against our pre-programmed beliefs and behaviours.

 **Concentration** takes energy and effort, especially when it goes against our inner feelings and motivations.

 We also **struggle with conflicting desires & thoughts** in a typical day. For example, we may enjoy an expensive dinner and drinks with friends after work, but feel guilty about spending money and not being at home with the kids.

However, “flow experiences” occur when the act of focusing and immersing in our experiences seem effortless.

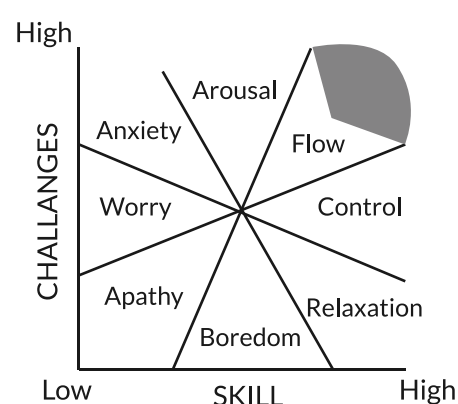
“A person in flow is completely focused. There is no space in consciousness for distracting thoughts, irrelevant feelings. Selfconsciousness disappears, yet one feels stronger than usual. The sense of time is distorted: hours seem to pass by in minutes. When a person’s entire being is stretched in the full functioning of body and mind, whatever one does becomes worth doing for its own sake...In the harmonious focusing of physical and psychic energy, life finally comes into its own.”

Being in flow typically comes with :

 **Clarity** of goals and required activities, i.e. knowing what to do .

 **Immediate feedback**, i.e. knowing how well you are doing.

 **High level of “skills” and “challenges”**, i.e. the challenges are big enough to be motivating but not insurmountable to cause anxiety, and you can use your skills to the fullest.



KEY QUOTES

“The only way to take over the ownership of life is by learning to direct psychic energy in line with our own intentions.”

“Given that attention is a limited resource, when one goal takes up all our psychic energy, there is none left over.”

“A typical day is full of anxiety and boredom. Flow experiences provide the flashes of intense living against this dull background.”

“The flow experience acts as a magnet for learning – that is, for developing new levels of challenges and skills.”

“It is the full involvement of flow, rather than happiness, that makes for excellence in life.”

“Flow is a source of psychic energy in that it focuses attention and motivates action.”

Excellence in life comes from being engaged in flow, not from pursuing happiness. When we are in flow, we direct our energy fully towards complex tasks, learning, and growing our consciousness. Flow is in fact a source of psychic energy, because it helps to focus our attention and motivates us to take action.



Finding Flow in Work & Leisure



Work is often seen as a necessary evil, while having free time to relax and do nothing seems desirable. However, evidence suggests the opposite – **work isn't necessarily bad, and leisure time doesn't necessarily improve quality of life.**



The Paradox of Work

Work is a central part of most of our lives, and typically takes up a third of our available time. **Work can provide meaning, focus, and challenge to our lives, yet most of us are glad to avoid work if possible.**

Many people resent their jobs for 3 key reasons:



The jobs are meaningless or even cause harm



The jobs are boring and routine (with no variety or challenge)



The jobs are too stressful (due to relationships with colleagues or superiors, lack of recognition etc.)

On the other hand, **work can be a positive experience** when it is perceived to be voluntary and we are satisfied with our results. This is especially so given how the concept of “work” has evolved over the centuries - from hunting for food, to manual labour, to an expression of skills and creativity today. Many modern professionals (e.g. artists, entrepreneurs) are enjoying much more intrinsic rewards from work that were not readily available in the past.

In short, we cannot blame our jobs for the lack of inspiration in our lives. Rather, **when we find flow at work, it helps us to develop new skills and opportunities for growth and fulfilment.**

KEY QUOTES

“Work is a strange experience: it provides some of the most intense and satisfying moments, it gives a sense of pride and identity, yet it is something most of us are glad to avoid.”

“It is always a better deal to do something one feels good about than something that may make us materially comfortable but emotionally miserable.”

“Without the goal and the challenges usually provided by a job, only a rare self-discipline can keep the mind focused intensely enough to insure a meaningful life.”

Csikszentmihalyi gave several examples of how people in seemingly poor or unenviable conditions found inspiration and fulfilment in life by focusing their energy on creating value for others, e.g. a lady who dedicated her life to helping homeless urchins who were in even more desperate conditions than her.



The risks and opportunities of leisure

Contrary to common perception, **free time doesn't improve the quality of life, unless it is used effectively.** In fact, people without goals and meaningful interactions tend to lose motivation, focus, and experience greater anxiety as their minds wander to unresolvable problems.

There's a distinct difference between active and passive leisure. Sports and active games are 3 times more likely to generate a state of heightened enjoyment than watching TV (while hobbies are 2.5 times more likely to do so).

To improve the quality of life, it is important to give our free time the same focus and attention as our work. **Ensure that your free time is used to explore the potential of the self and the environment, hence creating opportunity for flow,** which brings growth, fulfilment and better quality of life.



Finding Flow in Work & Leisure

To create flow and inspiration in what we do (be it work or leisure):



Pay attention, so you understand thoroughly what is happening and why. This helps us to understand the full impact of our actions (however trivial) on the whole, to give meaning, clarity and awareness over time.



Don't accept that the current way of doing the job is the only way – **explore and experiment** with new and better ways of doing things. No matter how routine a job or task, there are always small adjustments and improvements that you can focus on (and enjoy fulfilment from) if you treat it as a professional challenge.



Exercise personal control to prevent stress (which hinders flow):

KEY QUOTES

"Just as the excellence of an individual life depends to a large extent on how free time is used, so the quality of a society hinges on what its members do in their leisure time."

"To make the best use of free time, one needs to devote as much ingenuity and attention to it as one would to one's job."

"By taking the whole context of the activity into account, and understanding the impact of one's actions on the whole, a trivial job can turn into a memorable performance that leaves the world in a better shape than it was before."

"As minute changes can result in great discoveries, so small adjustments can turn a routine job one dreads into a professional performance one can look forward to with anticipation each morning."

"While everyone has the psychic energy needed to cope with strain, few learn to use it effectively."

- Develop a personal strategy that provides order & priority.
- Match your skill with the identified challenges. For example, learn a new skill, delegate a task, break up the task or transform it such that you can manage it.



Finding Flow in Relationships



Relationship with Others

Our relationships have a significant impact on how we feel and on our quality of life. To develop relationships, we need to invest energy in them. **A relationship that brings consciousness meets 2 conditions:**



Compatibility between goals, i.e. **shared goals**



A willingness to invest attention in the other person's goals.

How rewarding our relationships are depend on a several factors, including:



Socialization. Socialization shapes our behaviour, cultural expectations and aspirations, and hence affects how we experience life. We feel shame and guilt (as opposed to pride and accomplishments) when we feel we have let others down (based on social norms and standards).



Our friendships. The lack of friendship is a common personal complaint. In an ideal world, friends provide mutual benefits and stimulation to hone our skills and support our growth. However, in reality, it is common for friendships to provide a safe haven for us to preserve our self-image, without contributing to our growth.



Our sexual relationships. Fulfilling sexual relationships are another important aspect of a quality life. This come from neither celibacy nor promiscuity, but being conscious of the role of sexuality in our lives.



Relationship with Self



Being alone. Most people experience lower moods when they are alone than when they are with others. **The only**

KEY QUOTES

"Instead of promoting growth, friendships often provide a safe cocoon where our self-image can be preserved without ever having to change."

"If one has a hobby, or a rich inner life, then being alone is not only enjoyable but necessary."

time people feel better when they are alone is when they are in full concentration on a goal/ hobby or have a rich inner life.



Attitude towards “others”. People generally assume that people who are different from us – be it in race, language, religion, social class etc. – have different goals and cannot be trusted. Yet, we are fascinated by their differences. Being around strangers and different cultures bring excitement and creativity that improve the quality of life, so long as we believe that the “others” will share our basic goals and behave predictably within certain parameters.



Extroversion (expression through “public” action) versus introversion (ascension by looking inward). Extroversion and introversion need not be mutually exclusive. In fact, the most creative and successful individuals tend to embrace both ends of the spectrum – they set aside time for themselves (e.g. working alone from home, meditating) and create opportunities to meet others (to expose themselves to new possibilities, ideas etc.). By doing so, they have access to the full range of human experiences rather than box themselves into a corner and limit the possibilities of enjoyment.



Balancing Work and Relationships

The “balance” between work and relationships (family and friends) has been an ongoing challenge. People who love their work tend to direct so much psychic energy into work that their relationships suffer.

The solution to balancing work and relationships is to balance the meaningfulness of the rewards we get from work and from relationships. People are held together by 2 types of energy:

- **Material energy** (from food, warmth, physical care, money)
- **Psychic energy** (from investing attention in each other’s goals)

Successful relationships are like successful careers – they require an ongoing investment of thought and energy. In modern society, contracts and social control can no longer hold marriages together – only intrinsic rewards (i.e. mutual enjoyment) will motivate people to continue the relationships.

KEY QUOTES

“Instead of looking for models in the past, we should figure out what a safe yet stimulating social environment could be like in the future.”

“It is possible to be both extroverted and introverted at the same time. In fact, expressing the full range from inner to outer-directedness might be the normal way of being human.”

“Now that the integrity of the family has become a matter of personal choice, it cannot survive except through the regular infusion of psychic energy.”



Finding Flow in relationships

Creating flow in relationships involve **joint activities that help people to pay attention to each other**. For example, to make parenting a more rewarding experience, parents can:

- Pay attention to learn what the child is “into” or is “proud of”.
- Devote more attention to share such activities with the child, hence creating joint goals that everyone is investing psychic energy into.

Likewise, **when we are appreciated at work, we feel more satisfied**, because we feel that our goals are being supported.



Finding Flow through Awareness & Self-Development



To achieve excellence in life, we need to commit ourselves fully to experience all aspects of life & develop all of our potentials.



Awareness and Quality of Life

To improve the quality of life, **the first step is to start engineering our daily activities to get the most rewarding experiences**. There's no fixed formula, so it's important for you to find what works best for you. Start by **keeping a diary or reflecting on your day**, so you can become conscious of how you spend your time. Take stock of the activities and people that generate positive versus negative moods:



What you do: With awareness, you can **increase the frequency of positive activities and decrease the negative ones**. People in flow also tend to be so focused on the task at hand that they “forget” about their physical pains, fatigue and ailments. Csikszentmihalyi gave an example of how a mental health patient was able to rejoin the community and become financially self-sufficient simply by paring nails for others (an activity that brings her flow).



Who you spend time with. While companionship can improve the quality of experience, **real growth comes when we are with people who stimulate our learning**. Invest psychic energy in the right relationships.

KEY QUOTES

“When people pay attention to each other, or to the same activity together, the chances of flow binding the family increases.”

“The first step in improving the quality of life consists in engineering daily activities so that one gets the most rewarding experiences from them.”

“When attention is focused, minor aches and pains have no chance to register in consciousness.”

“It takes a total commitment to a fully experienced life, one in which no opportunities are left unexplored and no potential undeveloped, to achieve excellence.”



The Autotelic Personality

An autotelic activity is one that we do for its own sake, because experiencing the activity itself is the goal. For example, if you are playing a game because you enjoy it, that's an autotelic activity; if you are playing it to win a prize, that's an exotelic activity. **To have ownership of our lives, it is important to enjoy an activity for its own sake and in the process, learn to control our attention and direct our psychic energy in line with our intentions.**

People fall into a spectrum - some almost never feel that what they do is worth doing, while others **(autotelic people) feel that almost everything they do is important and valuable in its own right.** Those who are autotelic tend to:



Already feel so rewarded that they need very little material possessions or titles/power.



Be typically more autonomous and independent, yet are more involved or immersed in what's happening around them.



Have a seemingly inexhaustible supply of psychic energy: they pay attention more, notice more, and are willing to invest more attention in things for their own sake (rather than external rewards).



Be able to direct their psychic energy to experience life, because they are less concerned with themselves.



The Love of Fate

Leading a truly excellent life requires us to feel that we are part of something greater and more permanent than ourselves. **The challenge is to be engaged and carefree at the same time** – to be serious in our concern for the world at large, yet humble about the impact that we can make individually.



The starting point is to get a clearer understanding of our self-image – this imaginary entity tends to shape how we direct our psychic energy:

- Without a sense of self, humans will be like animals, exerting ourselves only to fulfil our biological needs.
- On the other hand, a sense of self based on wealth and

KEY QUOTES

"The point is to be happy while doing things that stretch our skills, that help us grow and fulfill our potential."

"Even the most routine tasks, like washing dishes, dressing, or mowing the lawn become more rewarding if we approach them with the care it would take to make a work of art."

"The important thing is to enjoy the activity for its own sake, and to know that what matters is not the results, but the control one is acquiring over one's attention."

"An active responsibility for the rest of humankind, and for the world of which we are a part of, is a necessary ingredient of a good life."

"Act always as if the future of the Universe depended on what you did, while laughing at yourself for thinking that whatever you do makes any difference."
- Buddhist advice -

power can lead someone to exert himself relentlessly at the expense of health and relationships.

- We cannot totally remove our ego. However, by developing a deeper understanding of ourselves, we can learn to separate the needs that support us in life from those that make our lives miserable.



It takes skill to reflect. When we have not mastered the skills of reflection, thinking about our problems tend to aggravate them instead of alleviating them.

- Hence, it is better to reflect on our life when we have reason to feel good about it – experiencing flow automatically helps us to feel better without even trying.
- To experience flow, it helps if we have clear goals to focus our attention on. Even if we are faced with a task that we hate or dread, setting a goal (e.g. to finish the task as quickly as possible) can transform how we experience it.

The love of fate, or *amor fati*, refers to our attitude towards our choices. **If we learn to take ownership of our actions and love what we have to do, our quality of life will be improved.**

KEY QUOTES

“The question is, why don’t we want to do more things? The sheer act of wanting focuses attention, establishes priority in consciousness, and thus creates a sense of inner harmony.”

“I want to learn more and more to see as beautiful what is necessary in things; then I shall be one of those who make things beautiful.”
- Friedrich Nietzsche -